sequent rethinking of archaeological methods for recovering the latter's physical traces, have helped to bring into focus a plausible picture, *viz.* a mercantile settlement that was adopted by an increasingly powerful and persistently transhumant elite as one of their seasonal encampments.

As is the case with most of the cultural geography of Afghanistan (see also below), all discussions regarding Jam-Firuzkuh and its surroundings in the mid- to late twelfth century must bear in mind at least three provisos, two historical and one modern. The historical provisos emerge from textual and archaeological indications: Juzjani mentioned that a flood destroyed the Firuzkuh *jami'* during the reign of Sultan Ghiyath al-Din Muhammad, but after his brother Mu'izz al-Din's successful India campaigns in the 1190s[16] – thus only a little more than two decades before the Mongol campaigns into Afghanistan (1220s). This "major depositional event" was documentable in the most recent archaeological exploration of the area east of Firuzkuh's famous *minar* – as discussed below, a zone that yielded a probable mosque or prayer area (Figure 3.1).[17] This natural disaster apparently wrought extensive destruction on what was likely the politico-religious focal point of the settlement, where other structures of note could have existed – and noted by Juzjani – but were ultimately swept away by the flood.[18] And of course we cannot discount the Mongols: in AH 617/1222 CE Firuzkuh underwent extensive destruction and large-scale slaughter of its remaining inhabitants at the hands of the Mongol Ögedey and his armies, so that much (if not all) of the city's pre-Mongol architectural fabric is no longer visible.[19]

Coupled with this compromised archaeological context is the forced incompleteness of archaeological survey and excavation. Given the endlessly fluctuating security situation in central Afghanistan, and governmental delays in issuing permits, the admirable work of Dr. Thomas and the other MJAP members had to be left only partially finished as of 2005. While he and his specialist colleagues in the field continue their analyses and publication of the data already collected (including GIS studies, ceramics, epigraphy, etc.; see below), many aspects of the site's archaeological context remain unexplored. All the observations offered below, then, must remain hypothetical, subject to modification depending on the emergence of more archaeological and other data over time, which may add detail to what is proposed here or open alternative understandings of the site.

Nevertheless, MJAP's explorations of Jam-Firuzkuh have supplied critical information regarding the erstwhile summer "capital," which *Tabaqat* lacked. The team's survey of domestic architecture, concentrated on the sloping west bank of the Jam Rud facing the famous *minar*, documented structural remains of well-built walls of stone, together with combination walls of stone and mud brick, some with plastered surfaces. The data indicated a populous terraced settlement, though likely of relatively short